meant by the Soviet Government as a piece of propaganda...and they probably know that it will never be much more than a piece of paper...British interests are not directly affected by the treaty.'[60] *Such calm acceptance of what one would have thought was a huge blow to Britain's position in Persia is perhaps indicative of the level of indifference the Foreign Office seemed to have towards that country by 1921. It also inevitably leads to a questioning of Curzon's motives in 1918– 1919, when he had seemed so fiercely against allowing a Soviet presence within Persia. Had the foreign secretary simply been using the spectre of Bolshevism as a convenient excuse to justify extending Britain's influence within Persia? For it seems that once the possibility of British hegemony over Persia had been thwarted, Curzon was nonchalant about the threat of Bolshevism to Persia.*

Or, perhaps, it was simply a case of sour grapes. Indeed, when in April 1921 the Bolshevik-inspired rebels in Gilan unexpectedly opened fire on the Cossack Division, the British Foreign Office seemed almost smug in its reaction. While the Soviet government denied it had any involvement in the events in north Persia,[61] Oliphant noted that 'the Russians are coming out in their true colours and the Persians will rue the day of their famous treaty'.[62] When, in May, Norman suggested that Britain use the Anglo-Soviet Trade Agreement to bring pressure to bear on the Bolsheviks regarding Persia, the Foreign Office declined.[63] The cynicism of that department towards the Persian government seemed to have now developed into something near malevolence. Having refused Britain's help, Persia was to be left to face the Bolsheviks on its own, while the Foreign Office looked on. In his speech to the House of Lords in July 1921, Curzon characterised the Persian government as being now willing 'to accept the caresses of the Soviet Government'. 'Caresses', he noted wryly, 'which usually end up by strangling those to whom they are applied.'[64] In the same month Robert Lindsay in the Foreign Office noted that: 'The Bolsheviks are pursuing towards Persia their usual policy pursued towards Bokhara, Georgia, and Great Britain. They make a treaty, then set up some other Power – Azerbaijan, Soviet Armenia, or the Third International over whom they profess to have no control, to tear it up.'[65]